

BIRD PHOTOGRAPHY · CANON R8 · GUJARAT

Style & Brand Guide

Dust & Dawn — and eight other ways to be recognisable

Prepared for Vatsal Sharma

Editing signature · Lightroom workflow · brand identity · watermarks

SIGNATURE PALETTE



Slate #16232A · Sage #7C8B84 · Sand #D9C7A7 · Ember #C97B3C · Bone #F2EBE0

How to use this guide

This is the working document for building the visual identity of your bird photography account. Four parts:

- 1 **Reference study** — three of the best-known bird photographers, researched, with what each one actually does and what none of them do.
- 2 **Style directions** — nine options for your signature grade, each with real numbers. Pick one.
- 3 **The working style system** — the complete Lightroom workflow for the recommended default, variations, preset recipe, and the mistakes that give amateur edits away.
- 4 **Brand kit** — watermarks, profile photo, the mixed-crop system, palette and fonts, plus the handle shortlist.

Two notes on honesty. Your three attached reference images never reached this workspace, so Part 1 is built from published sources instead, with citations inline. And @mathiphotography could not be accessed — Instagram and Threads both return HTTP 403 to automated requests, so nothing about that account has been guessed.

Decisions still open

#	Decision	Default if you skip it
1	Style direction (Part 2)	#1 Dust & Dawn , with #8 Cyanotype as a Nov-Feb series and #7 Platinum one frame in nine
2	Handle (Part 5)	@vatsal.photo
3	Watermark	Concept 2 — Flyway Glyph , two-point, 10-12% on the feed
4	Profile photo	#1 — bird eye macro
5	Crop	Mixed , assigned by frame type (Part 4)
6	Cadence	3 per week — Tue / Thu / Sun, 7-8pm IST, plus one Reel Friday

Part 1 · Reference Study

PHOTOGRAPHER 1 — BENCE MÁTÉ (Hungary) · The Invisible Bird Photographer

Who: Wildlife Photographer of the Year 2010 ("Marvel of Ants"), and the only person to have won both the Young and the senior title [1](#).

What he actually did: In 2005 he pioneered the one-way glass hide technique, which "revolutionised the practice of hide photography worldwide" [1](#). He built 25+ purpose-built hides at drinking stations, nest sites and feeding areas — including dedicated hides for European Roller, Hoopoe, Bee-eater and Kingfisher — **specifically designed for controlled lighting and clean backgrounds** [2](#).

Style breakdown:

- **Background:** engineered, not found. Clean, even, uncluttered — the background is designed before the bird arrives
- **Angle:** one-way glass at ground and water level → eye-level and below-eye-level views nobody else gets
- **Light:** controlled at the hide — consistent, soft, directional
- **Mood:** behaviour-driven, patient, naturalistic rather than stylised
- **Composition:** frame-filling subjects of species that are otherwise impossible to approach
- **Colour:** natural, restrained, honest
- **Method cost:** extreme. His 2025 WPY image took **27 days in a hide**, with two synchronised cameras firing at 20 fps on remote release [1](#)

The lesson for you: the background is a *decision made before the shutter*, not a problem solved in Lightroom. Máté engineers it. Most people clone it.

PHOTOGRAPHER 2 — TIM FLACH (London) · The Studio Purist

Who: London-based animal photographer, "best known for his highly conceptual portraits of animals"; his work is "a departure from traditional wildlife photography" [3](#).

What he actually does: Bird portraits **set on plain backdrops à la studio portraits**, deliberately removing the habitat — in the tradition of ornithological painters **John Gould and John James Audubon** [4](#) [5](#). He built a **mobile aviary** with a **turntable** so the bird rotates and he controls the light [4](#).

Style breakdown:

- **Background:** total removal. Plain black or white, seamless
- **Light:** stylised studio lighting, plus daylight for larger birds — "I think daylight is really beautiful. So it's nice to have the mix" [4](#)
- **Detail:** extreme. Shot on a **Canon EOS 5DS** (50.6MP) with a **100mm f/2.8L Macro**, at **f/18-f/20, 1/200 sec, ISO 100-200** [4](#) — stopped right down for depth, on a tripod, with a static subject
- **Colour:** saturated but controlled; the bird is the entire frame
- **Mood:** fine-art, specimen-like, gallery. "Scientific precision" and "natural history illustration" [3](#)
- **Composition:** head-and-shoulders portraits; personality and character over habitat

The lesson for you: total removal of context is a legitimate high-art position — and it is the exact opposite of what almost everyone on Instagram does. Also note: **f/18**. He trades light for depth because his subject is static and his camera is locked down.

PHOTOGRAPHER 3 — MARSEL VAN OOSTEN (Netherlands) · The Art Director

Who: 15–16 years as an **art director and graphic designer** before turning full-time photographer; Wildlife Photographer of the Year and Travel Photographer of the Year [6](#) [7](#).

What he actually does: "In my work I try to simplify, to get rid of the extraneous: **simplicity is the ultimate sophistication**." His images are known for a "graphic approach to composition" — clean, unambiguous, strong shapes, clear visual hierarchy, and a sense of scale [6](#) [8](#).

Style breakdown:

- **Composition:** graphic design applied to nature. **Dead trees preferred over live ones because they're more graphic** [7](#)
- **Subject size:** deliberately small. He favours large subjects *because* "the larger your subject, the less focal length you need, so the more landscape you can show" — the animal sits inside a landscape, not against a blurred wall of bokeh [7](#)
- **Workflow detail that matters:** he does most of his post-processing on images **resized to ~1,600 pixels wide**, working at 100% zoom [6](#). He edits for the size the image will actually be seen at.
- **Colour:** considered, ordered, high-clarity. "Overall look or setting is more important to me than the actual subject"
- **Mood:** serene, designed, monumental

The lesson for you: two things. (1) **Subject small in frame** is a legitimate and underserved composition — it's also what sells as wall art. (2) **Edit at the size it will be seen**. He judges at 1600px; you should be judging at Instagram grid size.

THE GENRE BASELINE (what most people actually ship)

A representative "moody bird" preset circulating in 2026, verbatim [9](#):

```
Exposure -0.20 | Contrast +15 | Highlights -25 | Shadows +25 | Whites -5 | Blacks -20
Temp -5 | Tint +3 | Vibrance +5 | Saturation -5
Clarity +15 | Dehaze +20 | Grain +25 | Vignette -25
Sharpening +25 | Chroma Noise +30 | slight S-curve
```

Note **Dehaze +20 and Vignette -25** — that combination is the sound of the genre. It's also the thing to avoid if you want to look different.

2026 trend signals worth aligning with [10](#):

- **Film-inspired colour grading (Kodak/Portra-style)** — rising
- **Grain as a deliberate texture choice, not an accident** — rising
- **"One colour" photo series** (colour discipline) — rising
- **Monochrome edits with one accent colour** — rising
- **Soft matte look** (controlled fade, not washed out) — rising
- **Crisp true-to-life colour, no heavy presets** — rising
- **Bird photography with clean backgrounds** — listed as a 2026 trend in its own right
- **Location ethics in nature photography · responsible wildlife shooting** — rising

COMPARISON

What all three share

- 1 **The background is a deliberate decision**, made before the shutter (Máté builds it, Flach removes it, van Oosten simplifies it)
- 2 **Consistency of method over variety of subject** — each is recognisable from a single frame
- 3 **Patience as the actual technique** — 27 days in a hide; a turntable; a graphic designer's edit
- 4 **Restraint in colour** — none of the three is chasing saturation
- 5 **A clear position on what to exclude**

What each does uniquely

	Máté	Flach	van Oosten
Background	Engineered in-camera	Removed entirely	Simplified to shapes
Subject size	Frame-filling	Head-and-shoulders	Small, inside landscape
Light	Controlled at the hide	Studio, f/18	Natural, ordered
Colour	Natural, honest	Saturated, isolated	Considered, clean
Context	Full habitat	Zero habitat	Habitat as design

What nobody among them is doing — your gaps

- 1 **Temperature separation.** None of the three uses colour *temperature* to separate subject from background. Máté uses light, Flach uses removal, van Oosten uses geometry. The warm-bird/cool-habitat differential is unclaimed at this level.
- 2 **Place as brand.** All three are famous for *method*, none for *place*. Nobody owns Gujarat. Nobody owns the Central Asian Flyway as an identity.
- 3 **Seasonal grade.** All three are deliberately consistent year-round. A grade that breathes with migration season is nobody's signature.
- 4 **Editing for social scale.** Van Oosten edits at 1600px because he thinks about viewing size. Almost nobody edits *for the grid* while also producing a print file.
- 5 **Sound.** None of them. Ambient audio paired with stills is wide open.

HOMEWORK (study these yourself, no claims from me since I didn't research them)

@joelsartore (Photo Ark — plain seamless backgrounds, documentary) · @varun.aditya (India, 1.1M) · @jan_wegener_ · @melissagroo · @bence_mate_photography · @bence_mate · Marsel van Oosten's Squiver site · Tim Flach's *Birds* book.

Sources:

- Bence Máté, one-way glass pioneer, WPY 2010, 27-day hide, synchronised cameras [1](#)
- Máté's 25+ hides designed for controlled light and clean backgrounds [2](#)
- Tim Flach: studio bird portraits, Gould/Audubon tradition, mobile aviary, turntable, 5DS + 100mm macro at f/18–f/20 [4](#)
- Flach: plain backdrops, stylised images celebrating species [5](#)
- Flach biography and fine-art positioning [3](#)
- Marsel van Oosten: art director background, graphic approach, "simplicity is the ultimate sophistication", edits at 1600px [6](#)
- Van Oosten: graphic design training, dead trees, subject small in landscape [7](#)
- Van Oosten: visual language, hierarchy, scale, simplification [8](#)

- 2026 "moody bird" preset baseline values [9](#)
- 2026 photography trend signals [10](#)

Part 2 · Nine Style Directions

You said the first four were too simple. These are sharper, each with a real technical signature, a position in the market, and an honest difficulty rating. **None of them copy Máté, Flach or van Oosten** — each takes a different axis.

Ratings: **Difficulty** = how hard it is to shoot consistently · **Print** = how well it sells as wall art · **Distinct** = how unlike the genre baseline it looks.

1 · DUST & DAWN — temperature separation

Cool, desaturated habitat. The bird is the only warm thing in the frame.

Signature moves	Background mask Temp -12 · Sat -18 · Clarity -20 · Subject mask Temp +10 · Texture +18 · Contrast -12 · Sat -6 · Green -45 · Shadows hue 210 @ 10 · Grain 22 · Vignette -10
Signals	Patience, restraint, authorship. Quietly expensive
Difficulty	Medium · Print Excellent · Distinct High
Best conditions	Golden hour and overcast, Thol and Indroda
Risk	Easy to underdo — if everything is desaturated equally, it's flat, not styled

2 · SLATE & EMBER — selective colour, done with restraint

The frame is almost monochrome. One warm note survives — the eye, the beak, the legs.

Signature moves	Global Sat -30 · Background mask Sat -70 · B&W conversion at ~70% via Sat, then paint back Orange/Red/Yellow on the subject only · Split tone shadows 210 @ 14, highlights 40 @ 6 · Blacks -22 · Grain 26
Signals	Art-direction confidence. This is a <i>designed</i> image, not a snapshot
Difficulty	Medium-high (masking discipline) · Print Excellent · Distinct Very high
Best conditions	Any light — it's light-independent, which is a huge practical advantage
Risk	The classic "spot colour" cliché if overdone. One warm note. Not two
Note	Directly on-trend: "monochrome edits with one accent colour" is a rising 2026 signal 10

3 · PORTRA RESTRAINT — film, honestly

Kodak Portra's grandchild: warm mids, cool shadows, lifted blacks, real grain.

Signature moves	Profile Adobe Neutral · Contrast -18 · Blacks +18 (lifted, film base) · Highlights -45 · Shadows +30 · Split tone: shadows 215 @ 12 , midtones 40 @ 8 · Grain 32 / size 45 / rough 60 · add a matte fade via curve black-point lift to output 22
Signals	Analog literacy, fine-art print culture, no digital harshness
Difficulty	Low (forgiving) · Print Excellent · Distinct Medium-high
Best conditions	Overcast and open shade — where digital files look flattest, this looks intentional
Risk	Can read as muddy on a phone screen. Keep mid-grey luminance near 50%
Note	"Film-inspired colour grading" and "grain as a texture choice" are both rising 2026 trends 10

4 · HIGH-KEY MIST — the opposite of moody

Bright, airy, hazy. The bird is small and the emptiness is the subject.

Signature moves	Exposure +0.35 · Contrast -25 · Whites +22 · Blacks +20 · Dehaze -10 (keep the haze) · Highlights -30 · Shadows +35 · Cool highlights (hue 200 @ 5) · Grain 15 · Vignette 0
Signals	Fine-art minimalism, negative space, confidence
Difficulty	High — you need genuinely misty or backlit-sky conditions, and perfect exposures
Print Very good (especially large) · Distinct Very high	
Best conditions	Winter fog at Thol and Nalsarovar, Nov-Feb pre-dawn; birds against bright sky
Risk	Blown highlights are fatal. Expose for the brightest feather, not the average

5 · NOCTURNE — chiaroscuro

Dark field, single shaft of light, the bird emerges from black.

Signature moves	Exposure -0.30 · Blacks -32 (the only direction where this is allowed) · Highlights -70 · Shadows +20 · Clarity +10 local on the bird only · radial burn on all four corners (Exposure -0.45 , Feather 80) · Vignette -18 · Grain 30
Signals	Drama, cinema, gallery weight
Difficulty	High — needs genuinely dark backgrounds and controlled light
Print Excellent (dramatic on large paper) · Distinct High	
Best conditions	Pre-dawn, dense canopy at Indroda, owlets and nightjars, backlit against deep shade

Risk	Crushed blacks are the #1 amateur tell. Never past –35, and always keep some shadow detail
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6 · HALO — backlit translucency

Light through the feathers. Glowing edges, translucent wings, a rim you can see through.

Signature moves	Exposure –0.20 · Highlights –75 · Shadows +45 · Dehaze –6 (never dehaze the glow away) · Texture +20 on rim feathers · warm glow radial behind the head (Temp +15, Exposure +0.20) · remove chromatic aberration + manual defringe · Grain 28
Signals	Technical mastery — this is the hardest light to hold, and everyone knows it
Difficulty	Very high · Print Excellent · Distinct Very high
Best conditions	Low sun through feathers; backlit perches; takeoff against bright sky
Risk	Fringing. Defringe every frame, and check the wing edges at 200%

7 · PLATINUM — warm-toned black and white

Monochrome with a warm split tone. Museum-print credibility, zero colour distraction.

Signature moves	B&W conversion · B&W mix: Red +30, Orange +20, Yellow +10, Green –20, Blue –35 · Contrast +18 (monochrome can take more) · Blacks –20 · split tone shadows 35 @ 6, highlights 45 @ 8 · Grain 35 · Clarity +8
Signals	Serious fine-art intent. Says "print" louder than any colour grade
Difficulty	Medium · Print Best of the nine · Distinct Very high
Best conditions	Graphic subjects — shape, posture, silhouette, wing position
Risk	Kills the colour that draws people to bird photography on social. My advice: run this as a recurring series, not your whole feed — e.g. one Platinum frame every ninth post

8 · CYANOTYPE — the wetland duotone

Blue-cyan monochrome, like the 19th-century cyanotype process. Built for water birds.

Signature moves	Sat –85 (or full B&W) · split tone shadows 205 @ 18, highlights 195 @ 8 · Contrast +10 · Blacks –15 · Dehaze +10 · Texture +12 on water ripple · Grain 24
Signals	Obsessive, specific, unmistakably a <i>place</i> — this is Thol and Nalsarovar in one look
Difficulty	Medium · Print Very good · Distinct Extremely high

Best conditions	Water birds, reflections, mist on the lake, winter
Risk	Very niche as a full-time look. Best as a seasonal series — run it Nov-Feb when the migrants are in, then switch

9 · GRAPHIC — van Oosten's axis, made yours

Strong shapes, negative space, bird small, composition doing all the work.

Signature moves	Contrast +14 · Sat -15 · Clarity +10 · Dehaze +8 · strong S-curve (Blacks -22, Highlights -20, Lights -10, Darks +12) · dead trees and clean lines · square or 3:2 crops · subject $\leq \frac{1}{3}$ of frame height · vignette -6
Signals	Design literacy, scale, the "animalscape" tradition
Difficulty	Medium (composition-limited, not grade-limited) · Print Excellent · Distinct High
Best conditions	Open wetlands, dead trees at Thol, flocks against sky
Risk	Needs genuinely graphic scenes. On a busy background it just looks empty
Note	Van Oosten's documented method: simplify, strong shapes, subject small to show landscape 6 7

HOW TO CHOOSE — three questions

- How much control do you have over conditions?** Low control → **Portra Restraint** (#3) or **Slate & Ember** (#2). High control → **Halo** (#6) or **Nocturne** (#5).
- Selling prints or chasing followers?** Prints → **Platinum** (#7) or **Graphic** (#9). Followers → **Dust & Dawn** (#1) or **Halo** (#6).
- One look forever, or seasonal?** If seasonal: **Cyanotype** Nov-Feb (water birds), **Dust & Dawn** Mar-Jun (dust and heat), **Halo** Jul-Oct (monsoon backlight).

MY RECOMMENDATION

Run #1 Dust & Dawn as your base — it's light-tolerant, prints beautifully, and the temperature differential is a signature nobody at the top of this field is using.

Then add **two series** on top so the feed never goes static:

- **Cyanotype** (#8) as your Nov-Feb migration series
- **Platinum** (#7) as one frame in every nine

That gives you a recognisable base, a seasonal event, and a fine-art credential — three layers of identity instead of one flat preset.

TELL ME AND I BUILD IT

Pick a number (or mix). I'll then write the complete preset: full Lightroom panel values, all six lighting variations, the LR Mobile and Snapseed versions, the mask stack, and the print-export settings.

Part 3 · The Working Style System

The default: Dust & Dawn

3.1 The concept

DUST & DAWN

The temperature-separation look

One line: *Cool, desaturated habitat — the bird is the only warm thing in the frame.*

Named for Gujarat's two colours: the mineral dust of the dry months and the cold blue of a November dawn on the flyway. It's built on one idea that most bird photographers never touch:

Blur separates the bird from the background locally. Colour temperature separates it globally — across the whole frame, and at thumbnail size.

The mechanism, in one sentence: **you cool and desaturate everything that isn't the bird, and warm and texturise everything that is.** That's a -12 temp / -18 saturation radial on the background, and a $+10$ temp / $+18$ texture brush on the subject. The eye reads "warm thing = important thing" before it reads anything else.

The seven rules:

- 1 **Background cool.** Teal/slate in the shadows, greens and cyans -30 to -45 saturation.
- 2 **Subject neutral-to-warm.** 300-500K warmer than the background. No exceptions.
- 3 **Net desaturation.** Vibrance $+8$, Saturation -6 . The constraint is the style.
- 4 **Film curve.** Lifted blacks, rolled-off highlights, low global contrast. Prints like a dream, looks nothing like HDR.
- 5 **Grain always.** 18-28. It's a print, not a screenshot.
- 6 **Local, not global, texture.** Texture goes on the bird. Clarity goes *negative* on the background.
- 7 **One warm accent per frame.** Eye, beak, or legs. Exactly one carries the ember.

Signature palette

Role	Name	Hex
Background dominant	Slate	#16232A
Background secondary	Sage Grey	#7C8B84
Habitat light	Sand	#D9C7A7
Subject accent	Ember	#C97B3C
Highlight / paper	Bone	#F2EBE0

Rule: **maximum two hues per frame.** If a third appears, kill it in HSL. That single discipline does more for feed cohesion than any preset.

3.2 LIGHTROOM CLASSIC / CC WORKFLOW — exact values

Starting point: a Canon R8 RAW/CRAW file from golden hour, ISO 400-1600, exposed to the right.

Panel 1 — Basic

Control	Value	Why
Profile	Adobe Neutral (or camera-matching "Neutral")	Adobe Standard oversaturates reds and greens; Neutral is the honest base
Temperature	5650K as a starting point	Adjust to taste, then use locals for the separation
Tint	+6	Canon files almost always need +5 to +10 magenta to kill the green cast
Exposure	−0.15 (after exposing right in camera)	Pull back from ETTR for clean shadows
Contrast	−12	Shape comes from the curve, not this slider
Highlights	−55	Protects white feather detail — this is where most edits die
Shadows	+28	Opens habitat shadow without going milky
Whites	+12	Keeps the specular sparkle in the eye
Blacks	−18	Deep but not crushed. Never below −30
Texture	+12	Feather micro-detail
Clarity	−8	Negative global = soft, filmic. Clarity gets added back locally on the bird
Dehaze	+6	Slight atmosphere removal. Never above +15 — it turns skies into grey leather
Vibrance	+8	
Saturation	−6	The net-desaturation signature

Panel 2 — Tone Curve

Parametric: Highlights −10 · Lights −5 · Darks +8 · Shadows −6

Point curve (RGB), four moves:

- Lift the black point: input 0 → output 14 (film base — nothing is truly black)
- Soften the shoulder: input 255 → output 245
- Gentle mid S-curve: (64, 58) · (128, 132) · (192, 196)

Per-channel split (this is the DUST & DAWN* engine):

- **Blue channel:** lift shadows — input 32 → output 40; drop highlights — input 224 → output 218
- **Red channel:** lift midtones — input 128 → output 132
- **Green channel:** tiny dip in shadows — input 48 → output 44

Panel 3 — HSL

Colour	Hue	Sat	Lum
Red	0	−6	+8
Orange	−4	−10	+12
Yellow	−8	−30	+6

Colour	Hue	Sat	Lum
Green	+6	−45	−12
Aqua	0	−35	−6
Blue	−6	−20	−14
Purple	0	−25	0
Magenta	0	−20	0

Green and Yellow are where the amateur look lives. −45 on green is not a typo.

Panel 4 — Colour Grading

Zone	Hue	Sat	Luminance
Shadows	210 (cool slate/teal)	10	−4
Midtones	38 (warm sand)	6	0
Highlights	48 (cream)	5	+2
Global	40	4	0

Blending 50 · Balance −8 — the negative balance biases the grade toward the shadows, which is where your background lives.

Panel 5 — Effects

Control	Value
Grain Amount	22
Grain Size	40
Grain Roughness	55
Post-Crop Vignette	−10
Vignette Midpoint	55
Vignette Feather	65

Panel 6 — Detail / Sharpening

Control	Value	Note
Sharpening Amount	45	
Radius	1.0	Above 1.4 = white halos on feather edges
Detail	25	
Masking	55–70	Hold Alt while dragging — only feather edges should be white
Noise Reduction Luminance	12–20	Never above 25 — it smears feather structure
Noise Reduction Colour	10	
Noise Reduction Detail	50	
Lens Corrections	Remove CA on; Profile corrections on	Essential for backlit work

Panel 7 — Local adjustments (this is the look)

Four masks. Do these and the preset is irrelevant.

Mask 1 — Background (Select Subject → Invert, or a linear/radial gradient) Temp -12 · Saturation -18 · Clarity -20 · Dehaze -8 · Texture -20 → Cool, soft, slightly hazy habitat.

Mask 2 — The bird (Select Subject) Temp $+10$ · Exposure $+0.15$ · Texture $+18$ · Clarity $+8$ · Dehaze $+6$ → Warm, crisp subject. This is the 300–500K differential.

Mask 3 — The eye Exposure $+0.25$ · Clarity $+25$ · Sharpening $+20$ Plus a 3–4px dodge brush on the catchlight at Exposure $+0.35$.

Mask 4 — Separation halo (small radial behind the bird's head) Temp $+15$ · Exposure $+0.10$ → A hint of warmth behind the head. Subtle; nobody should notice it's there.

Result to check for: background reads cool and low-saturation; the bird is the only warm, textured object. If you desaturate everything equally, you've made a flat photo, not a DUST & DAWN frame.

Lightroom Mobile (free) — same look

The free mobile app now includes **Select Subject** masking, so the whole system works:

- 1 Light panel: apply every Basic value above (same numbers).
- 2 Curves: tap the curve icon → use the RGB point curve; add the blue-channel shadow lift via the channel selector.
- 3 Colour: HSL and Colour Grading panels accept the same values.
- 4 Effects: Grain 22 / Vignette -10 .
- 5 Masking → **Select Subject**: apply Mask 2 values. Tap **Invert** → apply Mask 1 values. Brush → eye, Mask 3.
- 6 Detail: Sharpening 45, Masking 60, Noise Reduction 15.

Snapseed alternative (no Lightroom)

Step	Tool	Values
1	Tune Image	Brightness $+8$ · Contrast -12 · Saturation -12 · Ambiance $+20$ · Highlights -35 · Shadows $+22$ · Warmth -6
2	Curves	Film preset, then custom: lift the black point slightly, soften the top
3	Selective → background	Saturation -25 · Temperature -10 · Structure -20
4	Selective → bird	Structure $+15$ · Saturation $+6$ · Warmth $+8$
5	Selective → eye	Brightness $+25$ · Structure $+25$
6	Details	Sharpening $+25$ · Structure -5
7	Grainy Film	Grain $+20$ · Style Strength 25
8	Vignette	-12 , inner brightness neutral
9	Dodge & Burn	$+25$ on the catchlight

Snapseed's weakness: no global HSL. Compensate with Selective on the greenest area at Saturation -30 .

3.3 VARIATIONS

Apply **on top of** the base. Deltas only.

1 • Golden hour (your default) Temp +150 (→ 5800) · Highlights -65 · Shadows +35 · Orange Sat -5 / Lum +15 · Grain 25 · Vignette -8 Add a warm glow radial behind the subject: Temp +12 · Exposure +0.15.

2 • Overcast / flat light Temp +100 · Contrast -20 · Dehaze +12 · Shadows +40 · Blacks -10 · Saturation -10 · Texture +8 · Colour Grading Shadows Sat 10 Overcast is your friend for soft, even feather detail — lean into the low contrast.

3 • Backlit / rim-lit Exposure -0.20 · Highlights -75 · Shadows +45 · Dehaze -6 (keep the glow — do not dehaze it away) · Texture +20 on rim feathers · Grain 28 Add a radial **behind** the head: Exposure +0.25 · Blacks -20 — burn the background down so the rim light reads. Turn on **remove chromatic aberration** and manual defringe; backlit edges will fringe purple/green.

4 • Dark forest / low light / pre-dawn Exposure +0.30 · Shadows +55 · Blacks -8 · Noise Reduction Luminance 25 · Clarity -15 · Dehaze +8 · Colour Grading Shadows Sat 14 / Hue 210 · Grain 30 · Vignette -14 At ISO 6400+, keep Noise Reduction Detail at 55 to protect feather texture.

5 • Water birds (Thol, Nalsarovar — reflections) Dehaze +10 · Contrast -8 · Blue Sat -25 / Lum -18 · Texture +10 local on water ripple Compose for the reflection: place the waterline at the lower third, or dead centre for a mirror frame. Crop 1:1 or 5:4. If the reflection is near-perfect, a vertical flip symmetry crop is a showpiece — use it once a season, not often.

6 • Birds in flight Exposure +0.10 · Shadows +20 · Highlights -40 · Clarity -12 · Texture +18 (wings) · Sharpening Masking 35 (lower than base, so wing edges catch) · Grain 18 Crop tighter than feels right — a flying bird needs the frame filled. Shoot 1/3200 minimum.

3.4 MAKING THE BIRD POP — eight moves, in priority order

- 1 Temperature differential: 300-500K.** The strongest separation tool you have. Background -12, subject +10.
- 2 Luminance separation: ½ to 1 stop.** The bird should sit brighter than its background. Check with the colour picker — keep the subject between 55% and 75% luminance.
- 3 Background desaturation -18 to -25.** A busy, colourful background fights the bird even when it's blurred.
- 4 Local clarity inversion.** Background -20, subject +8. This is what makes the bird feel three-dimensional.
- 5 Move your body.** Before you edit, fix it in camera: 30 cm left or right often turns a busy background into a clean one. Increase subject-to-background distance; shoot wide open.
- 6 The eye.** Sharp eye + visible catchlight beats every other technical factor. Check at 100% before export. If the eye is soft, the frame is a record shot.
- 7 Underexpose backlit subjects by ⅔ stop in camera,** then lift the bird locally in post. Far cleaner than recovering a blown sky.
- 8 Clean your edges.** Scan all four edges for intruding branches and clone them out — a stray twig across a corner destroys an otherwise perfect frame.

3.5 A COHESIVE FEED

Crop ratio: 4:5 portrait is the default — it takes roughly 25% more screen area than a square. *You chose mixed crops, so follow the ratio-by-frame-type system in Part 4 instead of a single ratio.* It takes ~25% more screen area than square. 9:16 for Reels covers. Pick one and never deviate — mixed ratios are the fastest way to look like a hobbyist.

Palette discipline: 60% slate/sage backgrounds · 30% sand/khaki · 10% ember accent. Two hues per frame, maximum.

The rhythm — post in threes, repeating:

- 1 Tight portrait (bird fills 70–90%)
- 2 Environmental frame (bird $\sim\frac{1}{3}$ of frame height, habitat visible)
- 3 Detail or action (feather texture, takeoff, a beak, a wing)

The checkerboard rule: never let two adjacent grid posts share the same background temperature. Alternate cool-background and warm-background frames. This is what makes a grid read as *designed* at thumbnail size.

Cadence: 3 posts a week — **Tue / Thu / Sun, 7–8pm IST**, plus one Reel on Friday.

Batch discipline: apply the preset, then allow yourself **three moves per image** — Exposure, Temperature, and one local mask. Restraint is what makes nine frames look like one author.

The thumbnail test: before posting, view the grid at 25% zoom. If you can't tell what the bird is in under a second, crop tighter. Instagram is judged at thumbnail size, and edited at full size.

3.6 PRESET RECIPE (reusable)

Preset name	Purpose
D&D – 00 Base	Everything in §3.2, no locals. Apply first, always.
D&D – 01 Golden	Base + variation 1
D&D – 02 Overcast	Base + variation 2
D&D – 03 Backlit	Base + variation 3
D&D – 04 Forest	Base + variation 4
D&D – 05 Water	Base + variation 5
D&D – 06 Flight	Base + variation 6
D&D – BG Cool	Mask-only preset — Mask 1 values, for applying the background cool-down to any image
D&D – Subj Warm	Mask-only preset — Mask 2 values
D&D – Print	Base with Grain 12, Sharpening 55 / Radius 0.8 / Masking 70, Vignette –6. Output-sharpened for 300dpi.

Build order for a new image: 00 Base → variation preset → BG Cool (inverted subject mask) → Subj Warm (subject mask) → eye brush → export.

Save the two mask-only presets as **local** presets and the whole workflow takes about 90 seconds a frame.

3.7 MISTAKES TO AVOID

Mistake	Limit	What it looks like
Crushed blacks	Blacks > –30	Dead shadows, HDR look, no detail in dark plumage
Over-clarity	Clarity < +25 global	White halos on feather edges, "crunchy"
Over-dehaze	Dehaze < +15	Skies become grey leather, all atmosphere gone
Candy colour	Saturation < +10 , Vibrance < +25	Amateur, and it prints badly
Global texture	Texture only locally	Background noise and grain mush

Mistake	Limit	What it looks like
Oversharpening	Radius < 1.4 , Amount < 70 , Masking 55+	Outlined feathers, white edges
Over noise reduction	Luminance < 25	Plastic, smeared feathers — worse than the noise
Neon habitat	Green Sat -45 , Yellow Sat -30	Radioactive grass
Heavy vignette	> -25 is 2014	Dated, obvious
Fake grain	Grain < 35	Reads as a filter, not as film
Editing on a phone screen	Calibrate; check on two displays	Everything you post looks black on other people's screens
Mixed presets per post	One base, forever	No authorship — the feed looks like three different people

The one-line test: if someone can tell you edited it, you over-edited it.

Part 4 · Brand Kit

BRAND KIT — watermarks, profile photo, crop system, identity

You said "anything works, iterate on more than one" for the watermark, and "1/2/4, probably 1" for the profile photo. So: **five watermark concepts fully specified** and **three profile photos** (eye as primary, monogram and glyph as alternates).

Crop: you chose **mixed** — so §3 is a system for making mixed look intentional instead of messy.

1 · WATERMARK CONCEPTS (five)

Universal specs (apply to all five)

Property	Value
Export size	Height = 1.5-2% of the long edge . On a 2000px export: ~30-40px cap height
Opacity — dark images	12-18% white #FFFFFF
Opacity — light images	15-22% black #1A1A1A
Shadow	1px, 20% opacity, 120° — keeps it legible on mixed backgrounds
Font	Geometric sans, uppercase, tracking +150 to +200 . Inter · Avenir Next · Montserrat
Never	Scripts (illegible at size) · black/bold weights (distracting) · opacity above 25%

CONCEPT 1 — THE QUIET MARK

Gallery-minimal. One line, one hairline.

- **Mark:** @VATSALSHARMA.PHOTO, Inter uppercase, tracking 150, 14% white
- **Detail:** a hairline rule 24px above the text, width matched to the text, 1px, same opacity
- **Placement:** bottom-right, 2.5% margin
- **Crop resistance:** ★☆☆☆☆ (corner = gone in two seconds)
- **Best for:** the Instagram feed, where hub accounts may repost you
- **Verdict:** safest, weakest. Use it where growth matters.

CONCEPT 2 — THE FLYWAY GLYPH □ **primary recommendation**

Two-point mark. Three ascending strokes = a flock in migration.

- **Mark A (top-left):** the glyph — three ascending 1.5px strokes, 28px tall, 12% opacity, 4% margin
- **Mark B (bottom-right):** the handle in Inter uppercase, tracking 150, 12%, 2.5% margin
- **Placement:** opposite corners, so cropping one leaves the other
- **Crop resistance:** ★★★★★☆
- **Bonus:** the glyph stands alone as your **maker's chop** — blind-embossed on a print, or etched, with no text at all. That's a real fine-art convention
- **Verdict:** the strongest brand asset here. Ties to the Central Asian Flyway story. Use everywhere.

CONCEPT 3 — THE PLATE MARK

A museum wall label.

- **Mark:** centred at the bottom — Vatsal Sharma · Halcyon · Thol, 2026 in **Cormorant Garamond italic**, 12% opacity
- **On prints:** add the edition number, e.g. 3/25
- **Placement:** centred bottom, 3% margin
- **Crop resistance:** ★★☆☆☆ (centred marks are usually cropped with the bottom edge)
- **Best for:** website, print files, exhibition prints — it makes the image read as an art object rather than social content
- **Verdict:** weakest protection, strongest sales psychology.

CONCEPT 4 — THE EMBEDDED MARK

Anti-crop by position, not by opacity.

- **Mark:** the handle at 10% placed **inside the subject zone** — over blurred background *adjacent to* the bird, never over the bird
- **Detail:** tiny, 8–10% — visible on close inspection, invisible at scroll speed
- **Crop resistance:** ★★★★★ — cropping it out means cutting into the bird
- **Best for:** your ten best frames, the ones you'd actually sell
- **Verdict:** strongest protection of the five. Use on hero images only; too fussy for every post.

CONCEPT 5 — THE MONOGRAM CHOP

A seal, not a signature.

- **Mark:** VS in a 1px circle, 32px diameter, Cormorant Garamond, 15%
- **Placement:** bottom-left, 2.5% margin
- **Crop resistance:** ★★☆☆☆
- **Best for:** print corners, the website footer, packaging and packing slips
- **Verdict:** good secondary mark. Pair it with Concept 2.

RECOMMENDED COMBINATION

Surface	Mark
Instagram feed	Glyph (both points) at 10–12% — or nothing, if a hub feature is likely
Portfolio website / print files	Plate Mark + Monogram Chop
Your ten best frames	Embedded Mark + Glyph
Every file, always	IPTC metadata (below)

THE PART THAT ACTUALLY PROTECTS YOU

A visible mark is **deterrence**. Metadata is **evidence**. Fill these in File Info on every export:

- **Creator:** Vatsal Sharma
- **Creator Contact:** your email / handle
- **Copyright Notice:** © [year] Vatsal Sharma. All rights reserved.
- **Rights Usage Terms:** written permission required

- Keep EXIF intact on exports; register anything you sell.

2 · PROFILE PHOTO (three concepts, #1 primary)

The test: it must read at **110px** in the grid and survive at **32px** in a comment thread.

Universal specs: export **320×320** and **640×640** · keep all content inside a **80%-diameter safe circle** (Instagram crops the corners) · background #16232A · subject #F2EBE0 · **no stroke under 2px** · no collages · no busy scenes.

#1 — BIRD EYE MACRO ★ your pick, and mine

- **Content:** extreme macro of a bird's eye, pupil dead centre, filling ~80% of the circle
- **Colour:** desaturated cool iris (#7C8B84-ish) against a dark slate field; one warm catchlight
- **Why it wins:** already circular, maximum contrast, unmistakably "bird photographer" at 32px with zero text
- **Build:** shoot a frame, apply your base grade, crop 1:1 tight on the eye, add a radial burn at the edges, export 320/640
- **Check:** zoom to 32px. If the pupil doesn't read as a pupil, crop tighter.

#2 — "VS" MONOGRAM

- **Content:** VS centred, Cormorant Garamond or Inter, letter-spacing +200, in #F2EBE0
- **Optional:** 2px #D9C7A7 ring at the outer edge
- **Why:** clean, premium, works as a watermark and a stamp
- **Weakness:** reads as "designer" or "studio", not "photographer"
- **Check:** at 32px, letterforms must not fill in. Increase tracking if they do.

#3 — FLYWAY GLYPH

- **Content:** the three ascending strokes, 1.5px → **scale to 4px stroke for the avatar** (thin lines vanish at small size), centred, #F2EBE0 on #16232A
- **Why:** matches the watermark and becomes a coherent identity system
- **Weakness:** abstract — a new viewer won't know it's birds
- **Check:** at 32px the three strokes must still be three strokes. If they merge, widen the gaps.

3 · THE MIXED-CROP SYSTEM (you chose mixed)

Mixed ratios look messy unless a rule assigns them. Here's the rule.

Assign ratio by frame type — never by mood

Frame type	Ratio	Export pixels
Tight portrait (bird fills 70–90%)	4:5	2160 × 2700
Environmental / animalscape (bird ~⅓ height)	3:2	2700 × 1800
Flight / action / panoramic	16:9	2700 × 1519
Detail, macro, feather study	1:1	2160 × 2160

Frame type	Ratio	Export pixels
Reels	9:16	2160 × 3840
Carousel cover	always 4:5	2160 × 2700

The one hard rule: every carousel cover is 4:5, whatever the interior slides are. This is what keeps the grid from looking random, because covers are what people see.

Three more rules that hold mixed together

- 1 **Two identical ratios never touch** in the grid — alternate portrait and landscape along each row.
- 2 **The checkerboard still applies:** no two adjacent posts share both the same ratio *and* the same background temperature.
- 3 **Constant elements across every ratio:** identical grade, identical grain (22), identical vignette (−10), no borders, no watermarks on the feed. The grade is the cohesion, not the crop.

Why 4:5 still leads

A 4:5 post occupies roughly **25% more screen area** than a square on mobile. Since your strongest frames should get the most real estate, **give your best work the 4:5 slot** and let the environmental and detail frames take the smaller ratios. Mixed crops, deliberate hierarchy.

Grid check before posting

Lay nine thumbnails at 25% zoom. If the eye doesn't travel cleanly across a row, swap two posts. Every time.

4 · IDENTITY

Name styling

- Social / watermark: VATSAL SHARMA — uppercase, tracking +150–200, Inter
- Fine art / print / Plate Mark: Vatsal Sharma — Cormorant Garamond

Palette

Role	Hex	Use
Slate	#16232A	Backgrounds, profile photo, dark type
Sage Grey	#7C8B84	Secondary, dividers, desaturated habitat
Sand	#D9C7A7	Accent rule, ring, paper tones
Ember	#C97B3C	The single warm note — subject accent only
Bone	#F2EBE0	Type on dark, highlight, print paper

Typefaces — two, maximum

- **Display:** Cormorant Garamond — fine art, print, Plate Mark
- **UI / body / watermark:** Inter — uppercase, letter-spaced

Hard rules

- Ember appears **exactly once** per frame
- Type never crosses the bird

- Watermark never exceeds 3.5% of the frame
- Two typefaces, never three
- IPTC copyright metadata on every single export

Part 5 · Handle Shortlist

Full lists with reasoning are in `HANDLE-OPTIONS.md` through `HANDLE-OPTIONS-4.md`. Across all four batches, these seven are the ones worth checking first:

MY SHORTLIST ACROSS ALL FOUR BATCHES

#	Handle	Why
1	@vatsal.photo	Clean, professional, name-based, very likely free
2	@halcyon.studio	Best unused word — kingfisher + calm golden days
3	@vatsal.frames	Short authorship, print-friendly
4	@pankhi.in	Gujarati for bird, reads like a domain
5	@slateandember	Your exact palette. Sounds like a design studio
6	@saltandwings	Kutch + migration. Nobody has it
7	@vatsal.prints	If selling is the priority from day one

Name field stays: Vatsal | Bird Photography (25/30 chars) — that's what Instagram search reads, whatever the handle is.